

» In 961 CE, Otto invaded northern Italy and was crowned emperor by the pope, John XII, cementing the relationship between the papacy and the emperor of what would later become known as the Holy Roman Empire.

Feudalism in Europe

The term “feudalism” is used to describe the system of relationships between kings and nobles in northern Europe during much of the medieval period. In many ways it was the same system used by the Carolingian emperors, who appointed noblemen to administer areas of their empire in return for a certain amount of power and land, sealing the relationship with an oath of loyalty.

The feudal system that evolved in England and France worked much the same way as the Carolingian example.

The king assigned a parcel of land (known as a fief) to a nobleman; in return for the land, the nobleman swore to be loyal to the king and promised to perform various duties. First and foremost, he had to devote a set number of days each year to military service for the king. He was obliged to attend the king’s court, where he would give his advice on matters of policy and justice. He would also be asked to contribute payments for certain royal expenses—for example, when the king was building a new castle or a royal wedding was taking place.

A nobleman who entered into this kind of feudal relationship with the king was termed the king’s vassal, and he referred to the king as his lord. Many noblemen

apportioned part of their land to subtenants, who performed duties and swore allegiance in turn. This meant that the feudal system developed into a hierarchy of lords and vassals. The social networks that were involved could become very complicated, because it was possible for a vassal to accept lands from several lords. This kind of arrangement could lead to conflicting loyalties, especially if two lords were on different sides in a war. So vassals identified one of their superiors as their liege lord, the lord who took precedence over others.

France and England

The feudal system was most highly developed in France and England. Feudalism was already well established in France by the 10th century, when a



Knight's helmet

This 14th-century helmet was designed for full head protection. The wearer looks out through a narrow slit and there are tiny holes for ventilation.

Dover castle

England's first Norman king, William I, built a castle at Dover following his conquest in 1066, but the massive stone tower and inner walls were the work of Henry II, who upgraded the building in the 1180s. The stronghold was designed to guard the country against invaders arriving by ship across the English Channel, and its thick walls made it one of the strongest castles of its time.

The king's gateway

gives access to small walled area called the North Barbican, where attackers could be trapped.

Narrow slits

allow archers to shoot out at attackers. Small windows prevent attackers from climbing in.

Battlements

protect defending archers and provide a safe refuge.

The main floors of the great tower

contain a ceremonial hall for the king and smaller private rooms.

The walls of the great tower

are up to 21 ft (6.4 m) thick to protect the royal apartments from attack.

The forebuilding and entrance were guarded, acting as a barrier between the lord of the castle and intruders.

Spiral staircase in corner tower leads to storage areas below the castle.

